MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 3 — Unit 1: The Spectator Club and On Procrastination

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Steele creates a conversational picture of society through a fictional club, while Johnson turns the familiar habit of delay into a moral and psychological inquiry.

Start with a picture

One writer invites you to meet several talkative acquaintances. Another asks why the work you meant to begin is still waiting. Both use ordinary experience to make a reader examine conduct.

1. Steele: The Spectator Club

The fictional club gives the periodical a social range and continuity. Its figures are representative without being interchangeable: Sir Roger de Coverley is a country baronet; Sir Andrew Freeport is a merchant; an Inner Temple member represents another educated social role; Captain Sentry, Will Honeycomb, and a clergyman add further perspectives.

A **character sketch** joins selected details into an impression of conduct and values. The choice of details is part of the argument. A fictional club is not a neutral census of all eighteenth-century people.

2. Humour and social observation

Affectionate irony can expose an eccentricity without making its owner simply hateful. Differences of occupation and habit allow the essay to suggest a larger social world through a small group.

Ask whose perspective is presented as normal. The language of polite conversation can invite readers into discussion while excluding those not recognised as suitable members of that conversation.

3. Periodical form

A recurring publication and persona create familiarity. Each essay can stand alone while contributing to an ongoing relationship with readers. Addison and Steele’s collaboration helped establish that mode of public address.

The essay’s educational force lies partly in making reflection feel like agreeable company rather than an official lecture.

4. Johnson: On Procrastination

The essay examines how people delay action while continuing to imagine future improvement. Intention can become a substitute for the difficult act of beginning. Excuses, shifting projects, and excessive plans protect self-approval without producing a result.

A person may say that better conditions will arrive tomorrow, but the repeated postponement consumes the time needed for the goal. Johnson connects habit, limited life, and moral responsibility.

5. Sympathy and judgement

The analysis recognises a familiar human weakness. Its force need not depend on dismissing every delay as laziness. Distinguish Johnson’s moral argument from present-day situations involving illness, disability, exhaustion, or constraints he does not fully discuss.

For an exam, explain his reasoning and examples before proposing a practical or critical qualification. Do not turn the essay into an unsupported medical diagnosis.

6. Compare the styles

Steele’s social portraits encourage recognition through character and humour. Johnson’s reflective argument examines patterns within the reader’s own conduct. Both make prose a vehicle for improvement, but their tone and arrangement differ.

Quick check

1. Is the club a complete cross-section of society? **No.**
2. Does intending to work equal doing it? **No; that gap is Johnson’s problem.**
3. Does moral reflection require an impersonal voice? **No; tone helps shape the reader’s response.**

Build an exam answer

1. Identify periodical prose and its reader.
2. Explain selected club portraits.
3. Analyse humour and social judgement.
4. Trace Johnson’s intention/action distinction.
5. Compare methods and qualify their scope.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not turn a social type into a complete population study or treat every difficulty in beginning work as moral failure.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Compare the ways the two essays turn ordinary experience into reflection on conduct.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The two essays demonstrate the flexibility of periodical prose. The Spectator Club uses a recurring social fiction to make habits and values visible. The reader meets figures whose occupations and manners imply different relations to the world. Selection and humour turn these portraits into an argument about social conduct without requiring an extended formal treatise.

Johnson turns observation inward. Procrastination is presented as a recurring discrepancy between intention and action, sustained by the promise of better conditions in the future. The reader is invited to recognise the self-protective reasoning that permits delay. Moral concern becomes psychologically persuasive through the familiarity of the pattern.

Their methods create different relationships with an audience. Steele’s sociability encourages the pleasure of recognition, while Johnson’s argument more directly tests the reader’s self-description. Neither is merely an unshaped record of daily life. Persona, example, and sequence give the observation its force.

A strong comparison also tests the scope of their claims. Polite society does not include everyone, and a moral explanation of delay does not explain every actual difficulty. Such qualifications strengthen analysis when they follow an accurate account of the essay’s reasoning.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Bring out Steele’s gift for characterisation with reference to the description of the members of the Spectator Club.
2. Examine how the Periodical essays helped to capture the contemporary social ethos of the eighteenth century.
3. Give an account of English Prose in the Eighteenth century with special reference to Joseph Addison and Richard Steele. How did they make morality fashionable?
4. Examine the influence of Enlightenment thought on Johnson’s views of human will and action.
5. How does Samuel Johnson find correlation between idleness and procrastination

6. How does the writer describe the evilness of delay?
7. How does pursuing many goals lead to procrastination?
8. What are the major arguments that Samuel Johnson introduced in his “On Procrastination”?